



Down To Earth

Tremendous opportunities lie with every new technology—one only needs to know where and how to implement it to use exploit its full potential

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Google Earth has never been far from controversy. Concerns of national security and breach of privacy have kept Google Earth in the limelight.

But it is easy to look at the dark side of technology, forgetting what it was intended for. Those who have felt the need for those terabytes of data from satellite imagery, aerial photography and GIS have made it a part of their business arsenal.

Google Earth comes in four versions (see box *The Flavours Of Google Earth*), each meant for a different kind of user. We will not talk about the Basic and Plus versions here—they are only meant for personal use, and are not intended for businesses.

Earthly Professions

Google Earth Pro is being used in many businesses in the United States—insurance agencies, real estate developers and agents, NGOs and government organisations, the media, and asset tracking and security systems, among others. In each of these segments, Google Earth has helped businesses save millions of dollars, reduce their downtime, and increase efficiency.

Insurance companies are using software from companies such as Farallon Geographics, who use Google Earth to identify lands prone to earthquakes and flooding in areas in California. The identified hazard areas are then superimposed onto Google Earth. The data is so accurate that insurance companies are now able to tell if a building in an area is sitting on a fault line, and accordingly fix the premiums.

Car insurance companies such as GE Financial Insurance, Mercury Insurance, and Amica Insurance are now using Ensera's automated process for accident claims and repairs. Ensera is a technology company that develops automation processes for the automotive claims industry. Amica Insurance has fitted their claim agents' cars with digital cameras and laptops, which have software that uses Google earth with GPS tracking and mapping.

Real estate developers are a major target audience for Google Earth. In India, they, like their US counterparts such as Point2 and Earth Point (www.earthpoint.us) have started to use Google Earth. Real estate developers such as the Prestige Group and Goel Ganga Group, both based in Pune, have been using Google Earth in their businesses to show their clients plots they have for sale, or lock in on plots—through images—that their clients have to sell.

With the use of Google SketchUp, Real estate developers can make wireframes of their plans or create 3D buildings to place on Google Earth, allowing their clients to see how the plot is going to be developed. Roads, footpaths and fountains can be superimposed onto Google Earth. Rooms, windows, stairs, and balconies can be designed for the building, and the entire building can be built and modifications to the design done in hours.

Thousands of Realty Agents in the US, such as Just Real Estate Listings (www.justrealestatelistings.com) and For Sale By Owner (www.forsalebyownercenter.com) have created Web sites with Google Earth images woven in, so that clients don't even have to come to a real estate agent's office to buy a house!

We didn't come across any Indian real estate developers using this on their Web site, but it will not be long before they do.

NGOs such as Abbott Laboratories and UNICEF are using Google Earth to identify disaster prone areas, and for disaster management services to identify their coverage and reach. It helps them strategise rescue and relief efforts in the event of natural calamities, co-ordinating